The Assessment Of Ethical Behavior At Work

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Abstract

The purpose of this study is to develop a "model" of ethical behavior, at work, that places it within the context of individual job performance, and to develop specifications for rating scales of ethical performance. The specific efforts for summer 2012 included reviewing the existing literature on ethical performance, and comparing the substantive content of measures to the content of the 10 dimensions of ethical performance rating scales developed by HumRRO (Human Resource Research Organization). In addition, the content of measures was also compared to the existing rating scales for the Counter-Productive Work Behavior dimensions of individual performance. The results, their theoretical implications, and future directions are discussed.

Overall Objectives

The two overall objectives include:

1. To develop a "model" of ethical behavior at work that places it within the context of individual job performance.
2. To develop specifications for rating scales of ethical performance.

Obligations-Summer 2012

1. Identify all previous attempts to assess ethical behavior in the work context.
2. Compare them in terms of their:
   a) Substantive content
   b) Measurement objectives
   c) Methods of measurement
   d) Philosophical bases

Context & Assumptions

For the purposes of this project, ethical /unethical behavior at work is assumed to be one component of job performance when job performance is viewed as being multi-dimensional (e.g. Campbell's 8 factor model).



Business Ethics

Business ethics are specified as actions that are taken or not taken, in the work context, and which are judged as meeting or not meeting, an ethical standard. Such definitions imply that there are value systems (plural) that specify which behaviors are ethical and which are not, and that it may not be an easy designation to make in a given situation. There are also many contextual features that could influence what is perceived as ethical, or not ethical at any given time and place.

Unethical behavior is defined as follows:

Unethical behavior at work is behavior that violates a prescribed norm that is based on a code of behavior at work that is ascribed to by the relevant organizational or professional group. An ethical violation is an intentional choice, and it has at least the potential for doing harm to one or more of the organization's stakeholders. Among the relevant stakeholders are: stockholders, management, co-workers, customers, and clients. Ethical violations are not a function of a lack of knowledge and skill (i.e. simply inability to perform). They represent a conscious choice. The standards by which a prescribed norm is judged to be violated most likely have multiple determinants, such as national culture, public (i.e. government) policy, and the prevailing value systems of important stakeholders.

Methods

1. Literature Search of Journal of Business Ethics, and creation of a file of abstracts using relevant articles..
2. Identified studies that used one or more ethical behavior assessment techniques. using the abstracts.
3. Sorted the assessment techniques into categories (e.g. "tests" of moral reasoning, individual "perceptions" of the organizational ethical climate assessed via questionnaires, etc.).
4. Created a file of the actual measures in each category
5. Compared the substantive content of each measure (e.g. questionnaire items, vignettes, etc.) to:
   a) The 10 dimensions of the HumRRO developed ethical performance rating scales.
   b) The existing rating scales for the Counter-Productive Work Behavior dimensions of individual performance.

Significance of Study

The completion of this study will serve two major purposes:

1. Knowledge collected on ethical performance will be used to modify the approach used in the measurement of ethical behavior, which will result in more accurate measures for performance evaluations. This will ultimately provide a way of assessing ethical behavior for firms and companies.
2. Provide an opportunity to compare ethical performance to other components of performance. This will enable us to see the interrelations between ethical performance and other components of performance.

Preliminary Results

1. The dominant measurement methods are questionnaires and situational judgment tests (SJT's) which, use scenarios or vignettes of ethical behavior situations to which the individual reacts.
2. The dominant measurement objectives are:
   a) Assessment of individual *perceptions* of organizational *ethical climates.*
   b) Assessment of Individual *beliefs* about what behaviors at work are ethical and which are not.
   c) Assessing individual ethical performance in a simulated environment.
3. The initial 10 dimensions developed by HumRRO seem to encompass most, but not all, of the substantive content addressed by the current measurement methods.
4. There have been very few attempts to assess ethical behaviors/performance directly, in the job setting.

Tentative Implications

1. Currently there is no established method for measuring individual ethical performance.
2. The ethical performance rating scales developed previously in this project should be modified, and pilot tested in an actual work setting.

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